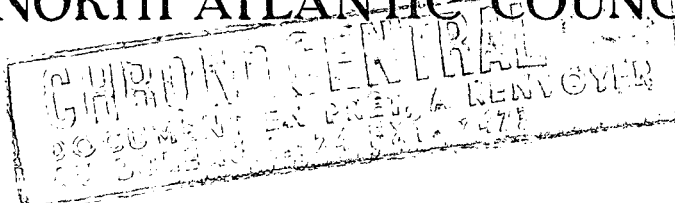


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NUCLEAR PLANNING GROUP

CONSULTATION PROCEDURES AND FACILITIES

DETAILED EXAMINATION OF SELECTED ASPECTS

Note by the Secretary

At their meeting on 4th October, 1973, the Permanent Representatives of the Nuclear Planning Group approved this report and the recommendations contained in paragraph 17.

(Signed) E.F. LUFF

NATO,
1110 Brussels.

This document consists of: 10 pages

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NUCLEAR PLANNING GROUP

CONSULTATION PROCEDURES AND FACILITIES

DETAILED EXAMINATION OF SELECTED ASPECTS

I. PURPOSE

1. This report examines selected aspects of procedures and facilities to be used by the Alliance for political consultation in time of tension or hostilities on questions of using nuclear weapons, makes recommendations for some specific actions to strengthen this consultation process and develops proposals for future NPG work in this context.

II. BACKGROUND

2. In fulfilment of one of its basic responsibilities(1), the Nuclear Planning Group has, since its inception, played an important rôle in developing improvements in the machinery for carrying out agreed methods of consultation with respect to actual or potential use of nuclear weapons in defence of NATO. As part of this process, a number of questions dealing with consultation procedures and facilities mainly based on the experience of WINTEX 73 have, at the direction of the Ministers, been under active investigation: the content of selective release messages and identification and handling of messages related to nuclear consultation(2) and classification and precedence of selective release messages(3). These matters are discussed in the following paragraphs.

III. DISCUSSION

3. The effectiveness of the nuclear consultation process is critically dependent on the ability of participants in that process to exchange information and views in a rapid, secure and reliable way. Since a major part of this information exchange will be in the form of message traffic, it is important to ensure that the content of the messages is clear and unambiguous, that the messages are easily identifiable to responsible officials as being relevant to the nuclear consultation process, and that they are handled rapidly.

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- (1) DPC/D(66)39, 7th December, 1966, paragraph 4(c)(ii)
 - (2) NPG/D(73)7, 21st May, 1973, paragraph 14
 - (3) NPG/D(72)18, 23rd November, 1972, paragraph 13

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Content of Selective Release Messages

4. Message Substance. Past discussions within the NPG concerning the content of selective release messages have tended to focus on the kinds and substance of the information to be included in such messages. This emphasis is reflected, for example, in the Provisional Political Guidelines of the Initial Defensive Tactical Use of Nuclear Weapons by NATO which, among other things, lists(1) the specific kinds of information needed by political authorities in consulting on requests for release of nuclear weapons. Much of this information would be included in the release messages. Since there appears to be general agreement on the kinds of information that selective release messages should contain, recent efforts have been devoted primarily to the clarification of details. There is a need to continue this work, which would be best accomplished by continuing to use the NPG as a forum for discussion between political authorities who require the information and the Major NATO Commanders who provide it. This dialogue should, among other things, assist the Major NATO Commanders in their efforts to be as responsive as possible to the needs of the political consultation and decision-making process. At the same time, it should help to give political authorities a clearer understanding of the factors that unavoidably limit the capability of the Major NATO Commanders to provide some of the desired information, such as predictions of the Warsaw Pact reaction to NATO's use of the weapons whose release is being requested, or forecasts about the exact location and precise timing of weapon employment in fluid tactical situations.

5. Message Format. More recently, the NPG has been concerned with another aspect of selective release message content, namely, format and terminology. NPG interest in this regard was stimulated by reports(2) of difficulties and delays experienced by political authorities in fully understanding the format used in release request messages they received in WINTEX 73, whose explanation depended on reference to other sources such as publications containing the Major NATO Commanders' Nuclear Weapons Release Procedures. Similar problems were encountered in understanding the meaning of certain terms and abbreviations used in the messages. It is in the mutual interest of all parties involved in the nuclear consultation process that the risk of misunderstanding release messages, or delays in understanding their meanings, be reduced to the greatest extent possible. In so far as political authorities are concerned, this objective can perhaps be most effectively achieved through the use of plain language in release requests wherever possible, particularly to identify the various parts of the body of the messages if the meaning is not clear from the text itself, and to describe

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- (1) DPC/D(69)58(Revised), 10th December, 1970, paragraph 106
(2) NPG/D(73)3, 17th April, 1973, paragraph 16

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delivery systems, weapons required or expended, and yields. On the other hand, there would appear to be no objection from the viewpoint of political authorities to the inclusion of weapons category abbreviations or weapons codes in a selective release request message in addition to the plain language, if the Major NATO Commanders originating the message considered this would be useful for the nuclear power concerned or for the military commanders who may be included as information addressees. In light of the foregoing, the Major NATO Commanders should be urged to use plain language wherever possible in drafting selective release messages addressed to political authorities. Obviously, others who may originate nuclear consultation messages should also be guided by the same considerations.

Clear Identification of Nuclear Consultation Traffic

6. In order to avoid inadvertent delays and misrouting of nuclear consultation traffic within capitals and headquarters after messages have moved out of the communications channels themselves, it is important that their content clearly show their relevance to the nuclear consultation process. In the report containing preliminary observations on WINTEX 73, it was noted(1) that certain messages pertaining to the release of nuclear weapons for selective employment for tactical purposes originated by the Major NATO Commanders, such as WHISKEY, SIERRA and ROMEO messages, contain within the message texts themselves a distinctive label (WHITE DOT for exercises; BLUE DOT for actual crises) that clearly identifies them as nuclear release messages. It was pointed out, however, that other messages also essential to the nuclear consultation process, such as reports of Council/DPC consultation, pertinent communications from member governments and certain other traffic from the Major NATO Commanders (e.g. Early Notification messages), do not carry within their texts any easily recognizable distinguishing mark that would clearly show their relevance to the nuclear consultation process. Since clear identification of all traffic addressed to, or originated by, political authorities in connection with consultation in time of war on questions of nuclear weapon release would be helpful, possible originators of such traffic to be transmitted on NATO circuits should be advised to insert the words "Nuclear Consultation Message" at the beginning of the text of each message.

Handling of Nuclear Consultation Messages

7. In one sense the foregoing measure to identify the substance of nuclear consultation messages within their text also contributes to their rapid handling on the part of responsible officials and their advisers. There are a number of

(1) NPG/D(73)3, paragraph 14

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equally important steps that could facilitate the handling of nuclear consultation messages within the communications channels themselves, such as having and using an effective precedence system, introducing special operating signals to ensure rapid handling of selected traffic, making effective use of address indicating groups, eliminating or reducing delays associated with classification requirements, and transmitting the traffic by the fastest available means.

8. Precedence. In view of the concern that has from time to time been expressed that the precedence assigned to nuclear consultation messages may be insufficient to ensure timely delivery to political authorities, the question of whether a special precedence for such traffic might be warranted was investigated in an earlier report(1). It was concluded that the present arrangements regarding precedence are workable, and that they should function effectively in time of war in support of the political consultation process. In this connection, it is worth emphasizing that the precedence assigned to a message by the originator not only gives instructions to communications personnel with regard to the relative priority to be accorded to the message in handling it in communications channels but also provides guidance to the officials responsible for taking action on its contents with regard to the originator's assessment of the urgency of the matter. Thus, if an originator assigns the highest precedence, FLASH, to an outgoing message, he is directing communications personnel to process the message through communications channels before any other messages of lower precedence, i.e. IMMEDIATE, PRIORITY or ROUTINE. At the same time, he is also advising the officials responsible for taking action on the content of the message that he considers the subject matter warrants highest priority attention.

9. There appears to be general acceptance within NATO of a view that in time of war messages related to the nuclear consultation process would be of such urgency and importance as to justify the assignment of the highest precedence, FLASH(2). In view of this and in the light of the strong and continuing efforts that are made in NATO to indoctrinate all message originators to use the FLASH precedence very sparingly, the validity of the earlier conclusion can be confirmed, namely, that the precedence system now in effect is workable and should, in conjunction with other measures, ensure that critical traffic

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- (1) NPG/D(72)12, paragraph 8
(2) In this regard, it is noted that the Major NATO Commanders in their Nuclear Weapons Release Procedures instructions have specified that messages pertaining to nuclear weapon release originated within their commands shall carry the highest precedence, FLASH

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would be handled rapidly and reliably in time of war. Accordingly, there is no requirement at the present time for a new precedence, higher than FLASH, to be reserved only for nuclear consultation messages.

10. Special Operating Signal. During Ministerial discussions of the need to expedite the handling of nuclear consultation traffic, the Supreme Allied Commander Europe (SACEUR) informed the Ministers that he had promulgated instructions to identify such traffic by a special operating signal to ensure rapid handling by communications personnel. This distinguishing signal is to be placed in the heading of certain high-priority traffic, such as alert messages and nuclear release messages, originated by SACEUR or by his Major Subordinate Commanders, to indicate to communications personnel that such messages are to be handled (transmitted, relayed, written up, delivered) before all other messages of equal precedence. Thus, a nuclear release message originated by SACEUR and carrying this special operating signal in its heading would be handled within the ACE communications systems prior to all other messages of the same precedence that do not carry the special operating signal(1). Only SACEUR and his Major Subordinate Commanders have been authorized to use this special operating signal, and only communications personnel within Allied Command Europe (ACE) itself are required to comply with its provisions on ACE networks. In view of these limitations, this approach had no direct effect on the political consultation process during WINTEX 73, nor would it be likely to have any real impact in an actual crisis. If the use of a special operating signal of this kind is to have any significant effect on the nuclear consultation process at the political level, it would appear to be necessary to make it effective on all NATO networks and to expand the list of originators who are authorized to use the signal to include member governments, the Council/DPC, and the Major NATO Commanders. Further experience with, and evaluation of, the special operating signal procedures as used in ACE may help political authorities in deciding whether to adopt a similar procedure for nuclear consultation.

11. More Effective Use of Address Indicating Groups (AIGs). To facilitate the handling of message traffic being sent to multiple addressees, certain Address Indicating Groups (AIGs) have been authorized for use on the NATO-wide Communications System. AIG 6006 and AIG 6007 have been allocated specifically for the purpose of consultation and exchange of political, politico-military and military intelligence and information. AIG 6006 covers Ministries of Foreign Affairs, the Major NATO Commanders

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- (1) Because of timing differences, it is unlikely that alert messages and nuclear release messages will compete against each other for high-priority handling

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and NATO Headquarters; AIG 6007 covers Ministries of Defence, the Major NATO Commanders and NATO Headquarters(1). In WINTEX 73 some countries reported delays in the delivery of important traffic to responsible officials in Foreign Ministries because some messages were addressed to an AIG that covered only Ministries of Defence, thus necessitating re-routing and relay within capitals(2). To help correct this situation, the DPC has, at the recommendation of COEC, agreed(3) in substance that in the future originators should include both AIG 6006 and AIG 6007 in the address of messages transmitted on the NATO-wide Communications System dealing with nuclear consultation and other critical matters which are of concern to both Foreign and Defence Ministries(4). In this context, the use of two AIGs in a particular message heading could carry the risk of inadvertent misrouting and resultant handling delays as well as the risk of duplicate transmissions. To reduce or eliminate these risks, the appropriate NATO authorities should be requested to take steps to introduce an additional AIG for use on NATO circuits that would include both Foreign and Defence Ministries in the list of addressees. Nevertheless, it must not be forgotten that the ultimate responsibility for ensuring that all of the responsible officials in the various Ministries and agencies in a government receive the critical traffic they require in a timely fashion rests with the nation concerned.

12. Classification. A previous report stated(5) that under existing guidance and procedures certain nuclear release messages (e.g. WHISKEY, SIERRA or ROMEO) originated by Major NATO Commanders are likely to contain ATOMAL information and would therefore have to carry an ATOMAL marking in addition to any other assigned security classification, such as NATO SECRET or COSMIC TOP SECRET. On that occasion, some of the implications flowing from the ATOMAL classification requirement were explored, with particular reference to limitations that might be imposed on the scope of consultation within the Alliance and the timeliness of such consultation. With respect to the scope of political consultation among Alliance members, for example, it might be difficult or even impossible for governments not cleared by the United States to receive and handle ATOMAL information to participate effectively in the nuclear consultation process if that process must of necessity use a nuclear release message bearing an ATOMAL classification as its focal point. Regarding the impact on timeliness, the processing and handling of messages carrying an ATOMAL classification is more complicated and time-consuming than that required for other classified, but non-ATOMAL, traffic. This was demonstrated as recently as WINTEX 73(6).

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- (1) NPG/D(72)2, 17th April, 1972, Annex B, paragraph 9
 - (2) DPC/D(73)11, paragraph 22(b)
 - (3) DPC/R(73)12, 14th August, 1973, Item III, paragraphs 28-40
 - (4) This double AIG address technique was employed on a number of messages during WINTEX 73 with good effect
 - (5) NPG/D(72)12, Annex, paragraphs 2-5
 - (6) NPG/D(73)3, paragraph 15

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13. In the earlier examination of this matter, some possible corrective measures were mentioned(1), ranging from a review by political authorities of their need for ATOMAL information to ways by which that information might be most effectively disseminated in the nuclear consultation process if the need is substantiated. However, exploration of these possibilities is complicated by questions that have arisen in the interpretation and application of the ATOMAL classification guidelines(2). Obviously, in considering possible corrective steps, it is important to know what information must be classified ATOMAL. It is proposed, therefore, that the examination of this problem be resumed when the interpretation of ATOMAL rules has been clarified by the United States Authorities, who have the matter under active consideration. In the meantime, the current procedures for handling the reproduction and distribution of ATOMAL messages in NATO Headquarters are being re-examined with a view toward streamlining the process to the greatest extent possible within existing security directives.

14. Use of the NATO-wide Communications System. With regard to the question of rapid handling of messages, the report containing preliminary observations on WINTEX 73 said(3) that exercise experience gave the general impression that the NATO-wide Communications System, to the extent that it was used, did in fact lead to an improvement in the speed and reliability of transmitting traffic related to nuclear consultation. It was reported, however, that there were some apparent problems and delays in the handling or transmission of release requests addressed to political authorities. After considering the WINTEX 73 report at Ankara, the Ministers noted(4) that WINTEX 73 again demonstrated the importance of having and using rapid, secure and reliable means of communication for the nuclear consultation process.

15. Later investigation confirmed that delays in transmission were attributable, at least in part, to the fact that the NATO-wide Communications System was not employed in all cases to its maximum capability. A report to the Defence Planning Committee (DPC) on the participation of NATO Headquarters in Exercise WINTEX 73 by the Council Operations and Exercise Committee (COEC) describes(5) the situation in some detail. At COEC recommendation, the DPC has agreed(6) that, pending implementation of the NATO Integrated Communications System (NICS), the NATO-wide Communications System should in the future be used for all cases where nuclear consultation or other traffic of

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- (1) NPG/D(72)12, Annex, paragraph 5
 - (2) C-M(68)41(Revised), 24th November, 1970, Annex III
 - (3) NPG/D(73)3, paragraph 12
 - (4) NPG/D(73)7, paragraph 15
 - (5) DPC/D(73)11, 13th June, 1973, paragraphs 17-22
 - (6) DPC/R(73)12, Item III, paragraphs 28-40

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critical importance has to be passed to the higher authorities of the Alliance. The DPC also agreed that, if the NATO-wide Communications System was inoperative, such traffic should be sent by the fastest available means. This is compatible with the provisions of General Guidelines for Consultation Procedure on the Use of Nuclear Weapons(1) which call for the use of the most expeditious means of communication available.

Further Work

16. This report and earlier ones(2) have discussed several separate but related aspects of the nuclear consultation process, all of which should now be consolidated into a single, cohesive package that would contain information and guidance on the details of the agreed procedures that would govern such consultation. This consolidation effort would be consistent with, and similar to, work now being carried out in NATO under the overall co-ordination of the Council Operations and Exercise Committee in the field of NATO crisis management procedures and arrangements(3). The compilation of nuclear consultation procedures could, when completed, form a contribution to the crisis management work now in progress under the aegis of the Council Operations and Exercise Committee. These detailed procedures would, of course, support, and be compatible with, approved policy guidance on nuclear consultation procedures(4).

IV. RECOMMENDATIONS

17. It is recommended that the Permanent Representatives:

- (a) approve this report;
- (b) invite the Major NATO Commanders to use plain language wherever possible in drafting selective release messages addressed to political authorities;
- (c) agree that others who may originate nuclear consultation messages should use plain language wherever possible;
- (d) agree that the words "Nuclear Consultation Message" should be inserted at the beginning of the text of each nuclear consultation message to be transmitted on NATO circuits to or from political authorities and invite the appropriate NATO Authorities to advise possible originators to do so;

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- (1) DPC/D(69)59, 20th November, 1969, paragraph III.3
 - (2) NPG/D(72)2; NPG/D(72)12; NPG/D(73)3
 - (3) C-M(72)46, 6th October, 1972
 - (4) C-M(62)66, 30th May, 1962; DPC/D(69)59

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- (e) agree that the question of a special operating signal deserves further attention;
- (f) invite the appropriate NATO authorities to take steps to introduce, for use on NATO circuits, an additional Address Indicating Group (AIG) that includes both Foreign and Defence Ministries in the list of addressees;
- (g) agree to resume the examination of the implications of ATOMAL classification when questions concerning the interpretation and application of the ATOMAL classification guidelines have been clarified;
- (h) agree to forward a summary report(1) to the Ministers which:
 - (i) reflects the above actions;
 - (ii) recommends that the Ministers agree that, for the purpose of political consultation on nuclear release request messages, the present system for message precedence is workable and that there is no requirement for introduction of a higher precedence for nuclear consultation traffic; and
 - (iii) recommends that the Ministers invite the Permanent Representatives to develop a compilation of nuclear consultation procedures.

(1) Later circulated as NPG/D(73)13, 9th October, 1973

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